Political Discontent and Regime Instability

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Data Availability Statement

Replication data is available on the Harvard Dataverse [link tbd], and the work's complete revision history is available at https://github.com/fsolt/trust_stability.

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Introduction

Political discontent is often seen as a threat to regime stability. When citizens lose diffuse support for the political system, they may become more willing to challenge existing political arrangements (Easton 1975; Gurr 1970; Muller and Jukam 1983; Craig and Maggiotto 1981). Yet we know less about whether political discontent increases regime stability. Does political discontent initiate substantial regime transformation? Does this relationship, if exists, differ between democracies and autocracies? And when transformation begins, does discontent predict whether political change moves toward democracy or autocracy?

Two measurement problems have made these questions difficult to answer comparatively. First, political discontent has been measured through distrust, perceived democratic deficits, dissatisfaction, political efficacy, and other related attitudes, and available surveys provide uneven coverage across countries and time (Jennings, Stoker, and Twyman 2016; Muller and Jukam 1983; Norris 2011). Second, scholars disagree about what constitutes regime change. Some datasets identify transitions between regime categories, while others measure changes in democratic quality or sustained episodes of regime transformation (Geddes, Wright, and Frantz 2014; Boix, Miller, and Rosato 2013; Maerz et al. 2024). Different measures therefore may identify different political events. Studying the relationship between discontent and regime stability requires attention to how both concepts are measured. These limitations have made it difficult to establish whether political discontent has different consequences across regime types and whether it contributes to the onset of regime instability without necessarily determining the direction of subsequent political change.

We distinguish between the conditions that make a regime vulnerable to transformation and those that determine where that transformation leads. We argue that political discontent is more strongly associated with the onset of regime transformation in autocracies than in democracies, and predicts the initiation of instability more clearly than its political destination. Democratic elections allow dissatisfied citizens to replace incumbents without rejecting the regime itself (Muller and Jukam 1983; Rooduijn, Van Der Brug, and De Lange 2016). Autocracies provide fewer institutionalized opportunities for such political replacement. Discontent may therefore be more likely to contribute to challenges to the existing political order. Once instability begins, however, its outcome

can depend on elite behavior, opposition organization, coercive institutions, and other political conditions(O'Donnell and Schmitter 1986; Przeworski 1991; Treisman 2020).

We examine these expectations using Public Political Discontent (PPD), which provides country-year estimates of diffuse political discontent for 136 countries from 1968 to 2023 (Ma et al. 2026; Solt 2020a). Our main outcome comes from the Episodes of Regime Transformation dataset (Maerz et al. 2024), which identifies sustained episodes along the democracy–autocracy continuum. We estimate discrete-time models of episode onset separately for democracies and autocracies, then examine the direction and eventual outcomes of these episodes. We use the method of composition to incorporate measurement uncertainty in political discontent (Y. 'Cassandra'. Tai, Hu, and Solt 2024) and compare the ERT results with the DD, BMR, and GWF regime classifications.

The results show a clear regime difference. In autocracies, increased political discontent is more likely to lead regime-transformation episode. We do not find evidence for episode onset in democracies. Among autocracies, however, discontent does not clearly predict whether transformation proceeds toward greater democracy or greater autocracy. Alternative transition datasets also show that conclusions about destination are more sensitive to how regime change is coded.

Our findings make two main contributions. First, we distinguish the initiation of regime instability from its political destination. In autocracies, discontent predicts whether transformation begins more consistently than whether it leads toward democracy or autocracy. Second, the comparison across regime datasets shows that conclusions about regime change depend on how scholars define and measure the outcome they seek to explain. Together, these contributions suggest that research on regime stability should distinguish the mechanisms that initiate instability from those that shape its trajectory, while treating the conceptualization and measurement of regime change as part of theory building rather than a purely technical choice.

Literature Review

The relationship between mass politics and regime stability is a long-standing question, and the literature on it is uneven in a specific way. Three points organize what we know: the first is well established, the second is contested, and the third has barely been

examined. First, mass mobilization moves regimes. It raises the probability of democratic transition and strengthens the democracies that follow (Teorell 2010; Chenoweth and Stephan 2011; Celestino and Gleditsch 2013; Brancati 2016), and Kadivar (2018) pushes the point further by showing that sustained mobilization leaves new democracies longer-lived rather than more brittle. This body of work settles a question about behavior. Whether mass attitudes carry the same force is a separate question, and the direction these studies report holds only for the campaigns they examine.

Second, whether mass attitudes move regimes at all is contested. Scholars have long expected mass attitudes to aggregate upward and shape democratic institutions (Welzel 2007; Inglehart and Welzel 2005; Qi and Shin 2011; Claassen 2020). Claassen (2020) supplied the strongest evidence to date, a large-scale cross-national time-series analysis in which support for democracy predicts subsequent democratic change in both pooled and split samples. That finding has proved fragile. When Y. 'Cassandra'. Tai, Hu, and Solt (2024) carry the uncertainty in the latent opinion estimates into the model, the association vanishes, and adding survey data does not restore it. The attitude at issue in this exchange is also a narrow one. Support for democracy measures attachment to a set of regime principles rather than discontent with the system citizens actually inhabit, and the next section develops that distinction. Even where mass attitudes do move regimes, the literature disagrees about which way.

That disagreement is stark. One body of work finds that mass mobilization hardens incumbents rather than dislodging them (Ulfelder 2005; Hellmeier and Bernhard 2023; Chin, Song, and Wright 2023), while the studies behind the first point find the opposite. Davenport (2007) explains why the question stays open, since the effect of repression on dissent has been reported with every possible sign. The two camps also work with different cases, outcomes, and periods. No defensible prior about the direction of mass mobilization follows from this record.

Third, mass attitudes have barely entered the study of regime survival itself. The canonical work on regime survival rests on coded regime events, the discrete transitions and breakdowns recorded in standard datasets, and mass attitudes have rarely appeared in those models (see Przeworski and Limongi 1997; Gasiorowski 1995; Boix and Stokes 2003; M. Svolik 2008; Houle 2009; Gassebner, Lamla, and Vreeland 2013; Geddes, Wright, and Frantz 2014 among others). Belkin and Schofer (2003) come closest, building a mea-

sure of legitimacy into a model of coup risk. Their legitimacy, however, is constructed from the competitiveness and regulation of the political system, with regime age as an alternative indicator, so it captures institutional structure rather than what publics actually believe about their rulers.

The evidence that does exist, moreover, comes from a narrow slice of the world's regimes. The big three literatures on declining support—critical citizens, satisfaction with democracy, deconsolidation—draw most of their evidence from consolidated democracies (see Norris 2011; Dalton 2004; Foa and Mounk 2016; Foa and Mounk 2017 among others), and even the scholars who attacked those findings did not go outside that evidence base (Alexander and Welzel 2017; Voeten 2017). Valgarsson et al. (2025) assembled a comprehensive record of institutional trust yet confined the regional and global trend analyses to countries counted democratic for most of the period. Autocracies sit almost entirely outside that record.

Whether that omission matters depends on why regimes survive at all, and theory gives two answers. One holds that regimes endure because citizens grant them rightfulness, and in the classic statements Lipset (1959) and Easton (1965) make a public's belief in the rightfulness of its institutions a precondition of stability. The other holds that regimes endure because institutions make compliance rational (Przeworski 1991). If compliance rather than belief does the work, discontent should be inert exactly where institutions offer an alternative government, and consequential where they do not. Two attempts to catch discontent destabilizing a regime came up empty. Booth and Seligson (2009) set out to detect exactly this effect and found instead that disaffected citizens neither withdrew from politics nor turned to destabilizing protest. Norris (2011) reports that a democratic deficit yields critical engagement rather than breakdown. That support for democratic government is eroding at all is contested in any case, since it has held steady where it has been tracked longest (Wuttke, Gavras, and Schoen 2022). Both studies, however, drew their evidence from democracies, where citizens do have an alternative government to elect.

Closing these gaps calls for a wide view and data to match. Regime change is rare, so only a broad and long panel turns up enough cases to model. The comparison at issue also requires democracies and non-democracies inside a single model, a range neither one country nor one region can supply. This study therefore develops an analytical framework

linking political discontent to regime stability and assembles a large-scale, harmonized dataset on which to test that framework.

Theory and Hypotheses

Why should the distribution of attitudes across a population bear on the survival of a political regime? The claim that durable rule requires more than force is among the oldest in the study of politics. Lipset (1959) argued that regimes endure when their citizens regard existing political institutions as the most appropriate ones for their society, and Easton (1965) supplied the account of how such beliefs operate. Diffuse support constitutes a reservoir of goodwill that allows a political system to absorb the failures and crises that any government eventually produces (Easton 1975). Where the reservoir is deep, citizens comply because they regard authority as rightful, and governing is comparatively cheap. Where it has drained, compliance must instead be purchased with performance or extracted through coercion, and both instruments are costly and prone to fail at precisely the moments they are needed most (Dahl 1973; Booth and Seligson 2009). Political discontent, understood as the absence of diffuse support, is therefore more than an expression of unhappiness with the government of the day. It signals that the arrangements by which power is acquired and exercised have lost their hold on citizens' allegiance, leaving the regime exposed when hard times arrive (Jennings et al. 2017).

Two mechanisms connect this erosion of support to observable instability. The first runs through mass behavior. Discontent lowers the threshold at which individuals are willing to tolerate, support, or join challenges to the existing order (Gurr 1970; Muller and Jukam 1983; Craig and Maggiotto 1981). As it spreads, the pool of potential participants in anti-regime action expands, and each act of defiance lowers the risk of the next, allowing local sparks to cascade into mass mobilization (Kuran 1991; Lohmann 1994).

The second mechanism runs through elites. No regime rests on mass acquiescence alone. Each depends on a coalition of ministers, officers, party cadres, and business allies whose loyalty is conditional on expectations about the regime's future (M. W. Svolik 2012). These insiders read public sentiment when weighing whether to stand by the incumbent order or to abandon it, and rising discontent tells them that the costs of defection are falling while the prospects of any challenge are improving (O'Donnell and

Schmitter 1986; Casper and Tyson 2014). Regimes are brought down in many ways, by coups, by uprisings, and by defections that hollow out the ruling coalition from within (Geddes, Wright, and Frantz 2014; Djuve, Knutsen, and Wig 2020), and each of these paths becomes both more likely to be attempted and more likely to succeed once the public has visibly withdrawn its support. Popular attitudes can thus destabilize a regime even where ordinary citizens wield no formal power, because those attitudes enter the strategic calculations of the few who do.

Together these mechanisms yield a baseline expectation. Where political discontent runs high, regimes should more often enter sustained periods of substantial change in how political power is acquired and exercised, what Maerz et al. (2024) term episodes of regime transformation.

> **Hypothesis 1.** *The higher a public's political discontent, the greater the probability that its regime experiences the onset of an episode of regime transformation.*

The destabilizing potential of discontent, however, should depend on the type of regime in which it arises. Institutions shape both what citizens can do with their discontent and what that discontent comes to mean. In democracies, regular elections give the dissatisfied a routine and low-cost way to punish those in power. Because incumbents can be replaced without disturbing the rules of the game, dissatisfaction tends to fasten on the government of the day rather than on the constitutional order itself (Easton 1975; Miller 1974; Citrin 1974). Przeworski (1991) describes democracy as a system in which parties lose elections, and it is exactly this perpetual availability of an alternative government within the rules that gives even deeply dissatisfied citizens reason to pursue change through the system rather than against it. Defeat at the polls, moreover, tends to reproduce consent among the losers rather than drive them from the arena (Anderson et al. 2005). Discontented democratic publics accordingly enjoy outlets short of regime change, in turning incumbents out, in protesting policies rather than institutions, and in supporting anti-establishment parties that seek office through elections rather than around them (Muller and Jukam 1983; Rooduijn, Van Der Brug, and De Lange 2016). None of this renders democracies invulnerable. Sustained discontent may corrode democratic norms from within or reward politicians who test institutional constraints (Norris 2011; M. W.

Svolik 2019). Yet such erosion is typically gradual, and it need not register as the onset of wholesale regime transformation. The channeling capacity of democratic institutions should mute, even if it does not erase, the association between discontent and regime instability.

Autocracies offer no comparable valve. Where rulers cannot be removed through routine and rule-bound contestation, dissatisfaction with those in power and dissatisfaction with the rules that keep them there collapse into a single grievance, and citizens seeking redress have few options that do not implicate the regime itself. Many autocracies do hold elections, but contests engineered so that the opposition cannot win perform little of the legitimating work of genuine alternation, and they sometimes serve instead as focal moments at which accumulated anger erupts (Tucker 2007; Knutsen, Nygård, and Wig 2017). Rulers can attempt to manage discontent with co-optation or with repression (Gandhi and Przeworski 2007), yet both instruments grow more expensive as discontent widens, and repression risks provoking the backlash it is meant to forestall (Davenport 2007). An informational pathology deepens the danger. Because the subjects of dictatorships have strong incentives to conceal what they think of their rulers, neither the regime nor its opponents can easily gauge how widespread discontent has become, and moments that suddenly reveal it can trigger coordination on a scale no one anticipated (Kuran 1991; Wintrobe 1998; Hollyer, Rosendorff, and Vreeland 2015). The discontent that democracies vent should therefore, in autocracies, accumulate, attach itself to the regime, and raise the probability that the regime enters a period of transformation.

> **Hypothesis 2.** *The positive association between political discontent and the onset of regime transformation episodes is stronger in autocracies than in democracies.*

Whether discontent also determines where such transformations lead is a different question, and here existing scholarship offers less guidance than one might expect. One tradition treats popular pressure as an engine of liberalization, and there is considerable evidence that mass mobilization raises the odds of democratic transition and strengthens the democracies that emerge from it (Teorell 2010; Chenoweth and Stephan 2011; Kadivar 2018). Another observes that threatened incumbents often respond to unrest by purging rivals, narrowing the ruling coalition, and escalating repression, so that popular

challenges end in harsher rather than softer authoritarian rule (Davenport 2007). The transitions literature has long insisted that the outcome of these contests is contingent, turning on elite cohesion, the organization of the opposition, the loyalty of the coercive apparatus, and no small amount of miscalculation (O'Donnell and Schmitter 1986; Przeworski 1991; Treisman 2020). On this view, discontent supplies the pressure that forces open a moment of contingency, but what happens within that moment is settled by struggles whose outcomes mass sentiment alone does not decide. The intuition is simple. Discontent gauges how much pressure a regime is under, not where that pressure will push it. The protest waves of 1989 and 2011 both grew out of deep popular discontent, yet similar pressures produced democratic transitions in some countries, harsher dictatorship in others, and state collapse in still others. If that is right, discontent should matter for whether episodes of transformation begin rather than for where they go or how they end. Its association with episode onset should be much the same whichever direction an episode takes and however it ends. A systematically stronger association with episodes of one particular direction or outcome would count against this expectation.

> **Hypothesis 3.** *The association between political discontent and the onset of regime transformation episodes does not depend on the direction those episodes take or the outcome in which they end.*

Political discontent, finally, is not the inverse of support for democracy. Discontent concerns citizens' evaluations of the political system they actually live under, whatever its character, while support for democracy concerns attachment to a particular set of regime principles (Easton 1975; Norris 2011). The two attitudes can and do diverge. Citizens of an autocracy may harbor deep discontent with their regime while caring little for democracy, just as citizens of a democracy may cherish democratic ideals while despairing of their institutions' performance. Claassen (2020) shows that public support for democracy helps democratic regimes survive, a protective effect that operates where the regime embodies the very principles citizens endorse. Our argument concerns a different attitude and a different mechanism, the withdrawal of legitimacy from the system citizens inhabit, and the logic developed above locates its destabilizing consequences chiefly in autocracies. Modeling the two attitudes together therefore permits a sharper test of each. Discontent should destabilize autocracies in particular, while support for democracy should stabilize democracies in particular.

Data and Measurement

While measures tapping political discontent abound in existing studies, no single measure of political discontent has won universal acceptance in the discipline. The lack of the universal measure can be partly attributed to the fact that scholars have defined political discontent in various ways. For example, some scholars, notably Easton, conceptualize political discontent as a lack of diffuse support for the political system, while others define it as low external efficacy, perceived democratic deficits, political distrust or dissatisfaction with incumbent leaders (Easton 1975; Jennings, Stoker, and Twyman 2016; Muller and Jukam 1983; Norris 2011). Different definitions of discontent have fragmented its measures, and each resulting measure has limited coverage across countries and over time. The fragmentation is such that scholars still debate whether political discontent is even rising worldwide (Jennings et al. 2017).

Following Easton (1975), we define political discontent as a lack of diffuse support for the political system. Diffuse support concerns perceptions of system legitimacy and serves as a 'reservoir of favorable attitudes or goodwill' toward a system. What distinguish diffuse support from specific support is its more enduring character and its consequences beyond any single government. As its name implies, specific support concerns support for the specific incumbent government, its leaders or its policies. It often fluctuates without a systematic pattern, and researchers have argued that it does not necessarily translate into rejection of the regime itself (Miller 1974; Citrin 1974; Craig and Maggiotto 1981) - not only because of its fluctuation but also because, in democracy, elections allow citizens to express dissatisfaction and replace leaders they are dissatisfied with (Muller and Jukam 1983). The erosion of diffuse support, by contrast, reflects systematically lower support for the basic political arrangements and can thus increase public willingness to seek radical change to the political regime (Jennings et al. 2017). As this paper examines how political discontent affects regime stability, the concept of diffuse support is better suited to our theoretical focus.

We rely on Public Political Discontent (PPD), a set of latent country-year estimates of political discontent generated by the Dynamic Comparative Public Opinion (DCPO) model (2026). The DCPO model is a Bayesian hierarchical item response theory model that estimates latent public opinion constructs of interest from multiple cross-national survey datasets (Solt 2020b). The latent variable model approach to public opinion esti-

mation was introduced to the field as a means of addressing the fragmentation of public opinion data across time, countries, and disparate survey items, and its applications have now extended to public support for democracy, policy ideology, and preference for redistribution (Berwick and Caughey 2025; Claassen 2019; Caughey, O'Grady, and Warshaw 2019). These models estimate the latent concept by gleaning information from multiple survey items while accounting for differences across surveys through parameters for question difficulty and dispersion, adjusting for country-specific item bias, incorporating responses from both dichotomous and ordinal questions, and smoothing estimates in years with sparse data while preserving cross-national comparability through dynamic priors. Drawing on the DCPO method, the PPD dataset assembles 388 survey datasets containing 111 distinct survey items tapping political discontent, covering 136 different countries over the 56 years from 1968 to 2023.

We use the PPD for three reasons. First, the dataset conceptualizes political discontent as a lack of diffuse support, aligning directly with our theoretical focus. Second, it provides, to our knowledge, the most comprehensive country-year estimates of political discontent, which offers an important methodological benefit: our results do not depend on the choice of any particular cross-national survey dataset (Claassen 2019). Third, the PPD estimates show strong validation results, including internal and external convergent validity and construct validity (Adcock and Collier 2001).

The choice of dependent variable deserves equal attention. As implied by the term itself, any measure of regime stability depends on how a political regime is defined, and the literature offers several distinct traditions (Cianetti, Del Panta, and Owen 2025). The procedural approach, which is the most common approach identified in Cianetti, Del Panta, and Owen (2025)'s review of regime studies, defines political regimes as the set of formal or informal rules governing how political power is acquired and exercised (Bjørnskov and Rode 2020; Boix, Miller, and Rosato 2013; Munck 1996; Schmitter and Karl 1991; Cianetti, Del Panta, and Owen 2025). This approach generally produces distinctions between democracy or non-democracy or autocracy, although the specific institutional criteria used to distinguish regime types vary across measures such as Polity, V-Dem and Freedom House.

Another influential tradition adopts actor-centered definition of political regimes, focusing instead on the composition of ruling coalition (Cianetti, Del Panta, and Owen

2025). Scholars in this tradition argue that similar formal institution can coexist with substantially different ruling coalitions, with important consequences for the behavior of political leaders and for whose interests are represented by politics (Geddes, Wright, and Frantz 2014). From this definition, procedural measures may overlook politically consequential changes in ruling coalitions that occur without a corresponding change in formal institutional rules, or may misclassify institutional changes, either improving or worsening the quality of democracy, by the same autucrat as regime change. (Wright and Bak 2016). For example, the Polity score fail to identify regime collapse such as the 1958 coup in Iraq when the regimes before and after the coup receive similar Polity scores and misclassify institutional liberalization in Gabon from 1991 to 1992 as regime change.

Beyond disagreement over what constitutes a regime, scholars also disagree over what constitutes regime change (Maerz et al. 2024). Maerz et al. (2024) distinguish between two dominant approaches. The transitologist approach focuses on transitions between regime categories and typically treats democratic transition and democratic breakdown as discrete events. The incrementalist approach, by contrast, conceptualizes democracy and autocracy as points along a continuum and examines gradual changes in the level of democracy. Further,they identify three major limitations of these approaches. First, each relies on restrictive assumptions about the comparability of observations. The transitologist approach assumes unit homogeneity by treating observations within the same regime category as comparable, while the incrementalist approach avoids this assumption but instead assumes constant and symmetric effects of factors for both improving or decreasing quality of democracy. Second, both approaches tend to operationalize regime change through annual observations, potentially amplifying short-term fluctuations even though regime transformation often unfolds gradually over multiple years. Third, the two approaches have difficulty incorporating democratization and autocratization within a common framework. Transitologist studies generally treat democratic transition and democratic breakdown as separate processes, whereas incrementalist studies often treat equivalent movements toward and away from democracy as empirically comparable changes. Maerz et al. therefore conceptualize regime change as a sustained and substantial process that may or may not ultimately result in a discrete regime transition.

In this paper, we adopt a procedural conception of political regimes. Because this

is the dominant approach in the existing empirical literature, doing so allows our findings to engage directly with a broad literature on democratization, autocratization, and regime stability. At the same time, to address the limitations of both the transitologist and incrementalist approaches, we rely on the Episodes of Regime Transformation (ERT) dataset (Maerz et al. 2024). Rather than identifying regime change solely from discrete transitions or annual changes in democracy scores, the ERT dataset identifies sustained episodes of substantial change along the democracy–autocracy continuum. Using these data, we first examine whether higher levels of political discontent are associated with the onset of regime-transformation episodes. However, rather than assuming that the effect of political discontent on regime stability is the same across regime types, we allow its effect to vary between democracies and autocracies (Claassen 2020; Y. 'Cassandra'. Tai, Hu, and Solt 2024). Specifically, we use the regime-type classification provided by the ERT dataset to construct two regime-specific measures of political discontent: political discontent in democracies and political discontent in autocracies. Each measure varies with the underlying level of political discontent only when a country belongs to the corresponding regime type and is coded zero otherwise. We include both measures, together with the regime-type indicator, in the same model, to estimate separately the association between political discontent and the onset of regime transformation in democracies and autocracies. We further distinguish the direction of these episodes and examine whether political discontent is associated with the onset of episode resulting in specific outcomes, such as democratization or autocratization. This approach can examine whether political discontent contributes to the initiation of regime transformation while avoiding the assumption that all transformations lead to the same outcome.

To examine these relationships, we employ discrete-time logistic regression, which models how covariates affect the probability that an episode begins within discrete time intervals. This approach is appropriate because our dependent variable, the onset of episode, is measured in country-years. We consequently do not employ continuous-time hazard models such as the Cox proportional hazards model. For each specification, we estimate both conventional logistic regression using a generalized linear model (GLM) and Firth's penalized-likelihood logistic regression (Puhr et al. 2017; Muchlinski et al. 2016). The latter provides a robustness check against small-sample bias and separation that may arise when regime-transformation onsets are relatively rare events.

To account for measurement uncertainty in political discontent, we use the method of composition (MOC). The MOC repeatedly draws 900 simulated values of political discontent from its estimated distribution, re-estimates each model using each draw, and combines the resulting estimates into a final distribution of coefficients (Y. 'Cassandra'. Tai, Hu, and Solt 2024). This procedure propagates uncertainty from the measurement of political discontent into the uncertainty surrounding our regression estimates. The models also include a standard set of covariates associated with regime transformation: logged GDP per capita, GDP growth, regional democracy, the percentage of the population that is Muslim, resource dependence, OECD membership, income inequality measured using SWIID 9.8, and logged population. We additionally account for temporal dependence by including the regime-age clock, its squared term, and a count of previous transitions. We also include public support for democracy as a control (Claassen 2020; Choi 2026).

Results

Figure 1 presents the estimated association between political discontent and the onset of regime-transformation episodes separately for democracies and autocracies. The results reveal a clear difference across regime types. In autocracies, higher political discontent is positively and significantly associated with the onset of regime transformation episode. A one-standard-deviation increase in political discontent is associated with an average increase of 5.0 percentage points in the probability of episode onset (95% credible interval: 1.0 to 9.9), net of the other variables included in the model. This substantive association is particularly notable because it represents the largest estimated change in the probability of episode onset among the variables included in the model. By contrast, political discontent is not significantly associated with episode onset in democracies, although its point estimate is also positive.

Taken together, these results are consistent with the expectation that political discontent is associated with greater regime instability, but suggest that this relationship is concentrated in autocratic regimes. One possible explanation for this regime-specific pattern is that democratic elections provide an institutional mechanism through which political discontent can be channeled without necessarily threatening the regime itself (Ma et al. 2026). In democracies, dissatisfied citizens can replace incumbent leaders

through elections rather than translating dissatisfaction with political authorities into rejection of the political regime (Muller and Jukam 1983; Rooduijn, Van Der Brug, and De Lange 2016). Autocracies generally provide fewer institutionalized opportunities for such electoral replacement, making accumulated political discontent more likely to coincide with broader pressures for regime transformation.

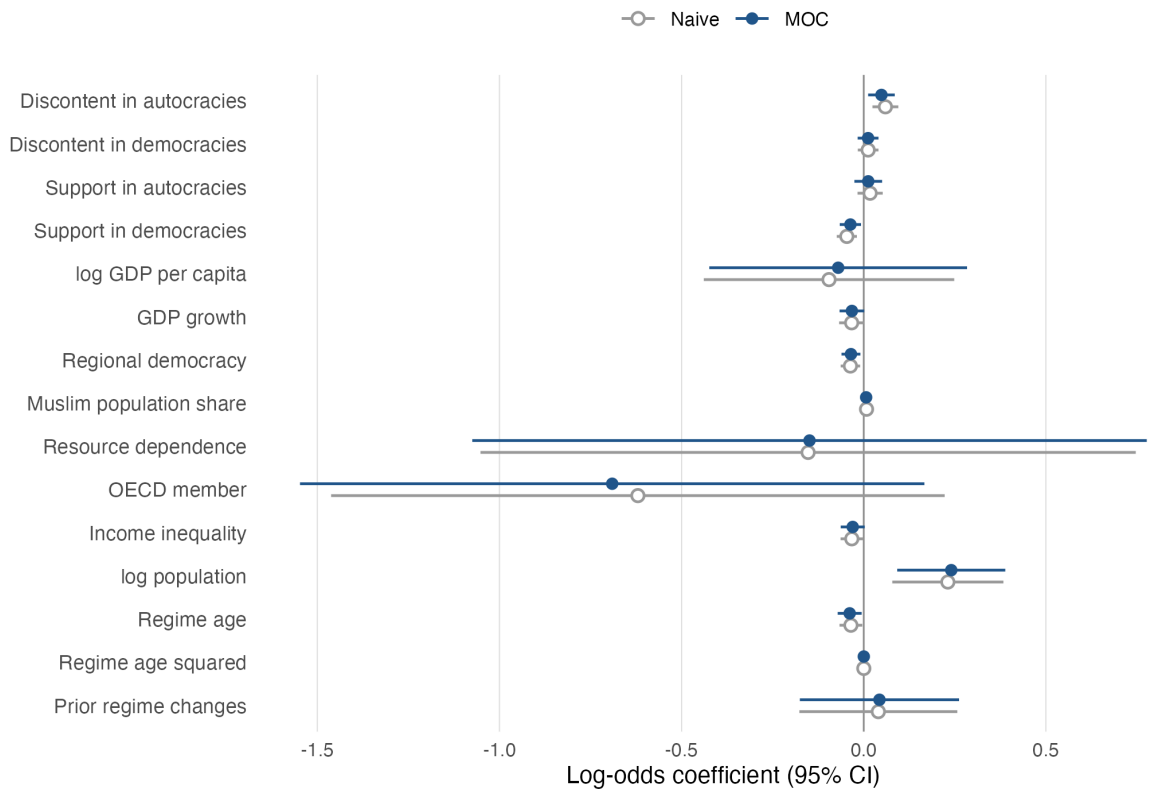


Figure 1: Coefficients from the discrete-time hazard model of episode onset.

Public support for democracy exhibits a different regime-specific pattern. In autocracies, democratic support is not significantly associated with the onset of regime-transformation episodes. In democracies, however, higher support for democracy is negatively and significantly associated with episode onset. A one-standard-deviation increase in support is associated with an average reduction of 1.4 percentage points in the probability of episode onset (95% credible interval: 0.4 to 2.2). It should not, however, be interpreted as direct evidence that democratic support reduces the probability of democratic breakdown. The dependent variable captures the onset of substantial and sustained transformation in either direction along the democracy–autocracy continuum. Among democracies, therefore, a lower probability of episode onset could reflect a lower likelihood of democratic regression, democratic deepening, or both. We examine the direction

and eventual outcomes of these transformation episodes separately below. Among the control variables, regional democracy and regime age are negatively associated with episode onset, whereas population size is positively associated with it. GDP growth also shows a negative, although only marginally significant, association with episode onset, consistent with previous evidence linking stronger economic performance to greater regime stability (Gassebner, Lamla, and Vreeland 2013). The remaining covariates are not statistically distinguishable from zero at conventional levels after accounting for measurement uncertainty.

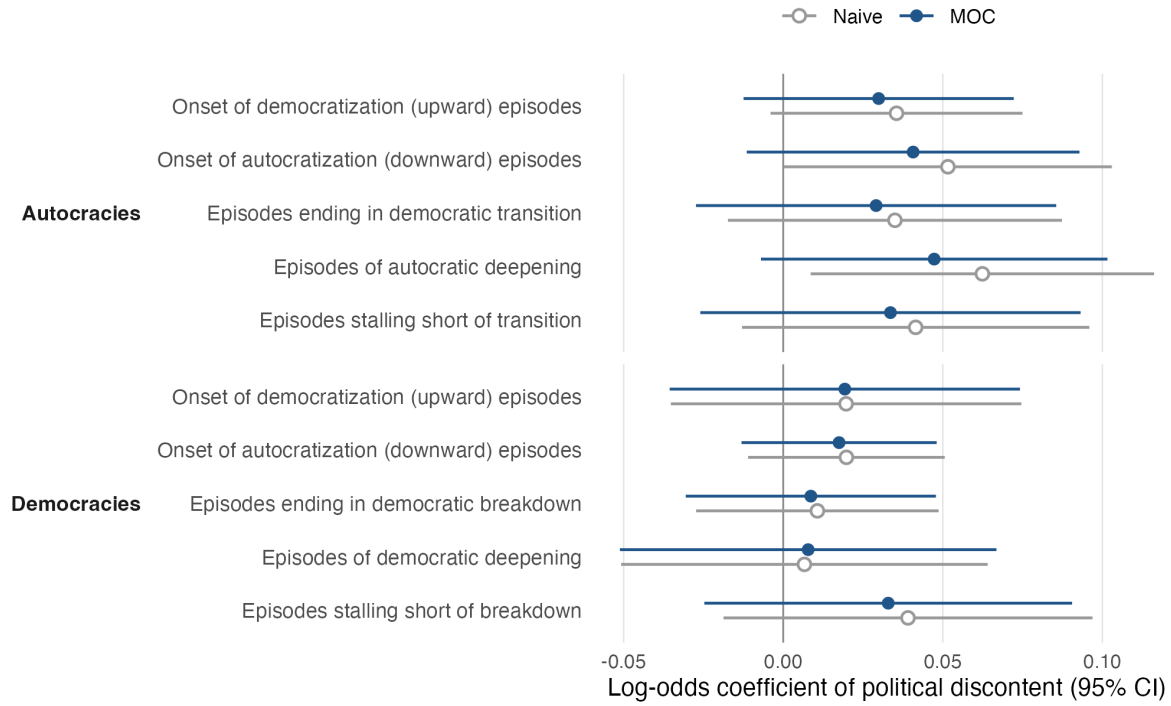


Figure 2: Coefficients from discrete-time hazard models of direction-specific and outcome-specific episode onset.

Figure 2 further examines whether the destabilizing association of political discontent in autocracies takes a particular direction—upward (democratization episodes) or downward (autocratization episodes) along the democracy–autocracy continuum. It should be noted that democratization and autocratization here do not necessarily denote transitions across regime types. Instead, they represent sustained movement up or down the continuum, following Maerz et al. (2024). The top two whiskers for each group, autocracies and democracies, show the association of political discontent with the onset of episodes in each direction. In autocracies, the estimated association of political discontent is positive for the onset of both democratization episodes (95% credible interval: -0.012 to

0.074) and autocratization episodes (95% credible interval: -0.012 to 0.093), but neither estimate is statistically distinguishable from zero after accounting for measurement uncertainty. A similar absence of significant associations appears among democracies. These results suggest that, although political discontent increases the overall likelihood that an autocratic regime enters a period of transformation, it does not systematically push that transformation in either a democratic or an autocratic direction.

The remaining three whiskers for each group shift attention from the direction of an episode to its eventual outcome, drawing on the ERT dataset's outcome classifications. Consistent with the results above, political discontent is not significantly associated with whether liberalization in an autocracy ultimately produces a democratic transition or stalls short of one; nor does it significantly predict democratic deepening, democratic breakdown, or episodes that stall short of breakdown among democracies. The largest outcome-specific estimate appears for autocratic deepening (95% credible interval: -0.003 to 0.104). Notably, both this association and the association with autocratization-episode onset in autocracies are statistically significant in the naïve estimates, which do not account for measurement uncertainty in political discontent ($p = 0.023$ and $p = 0.049$, respectively). However, both lose statistical significance once this measurement uncertainty is incorporated. Taken together, these findings indicate that political discontent operates primarily as a destabilizing force in autocratic regimes. It is associated with whether an autocracy enters a sustained period of regime transformation, and this association does not depend systematically on the direction that transformation takes or the outcome it ultimately produces. Political discontent therefore predicts the initiation of regime instability more clearly than its political destination.

To assess whether our conclusions depend on the ERT coding of regime transformation, we re-estimate the transition models using three widely used dichotomous regime classifications: the DD classification of Cheibub, Gandhi, and Vreeland, as updated by Bjørnskov and Rode (2020), the Boix–Miller–Rosato (BMR) measure (Boix, Miller, and Rosato 2013), and the Geddes–Wright–Frantz (GWF) classification (Geddes, Wright, and Frantz 2014). The results are presented in Figure 3. Under both DD and BMR, political discontent in autocracies is positively associated with a transition to democracy (DD: 95% credible interval: 0.003 to 0.091; BMR: 95% credible interval: 0.019 to 0.114). By contrast, political discontent is not associated with regime transitions originating in

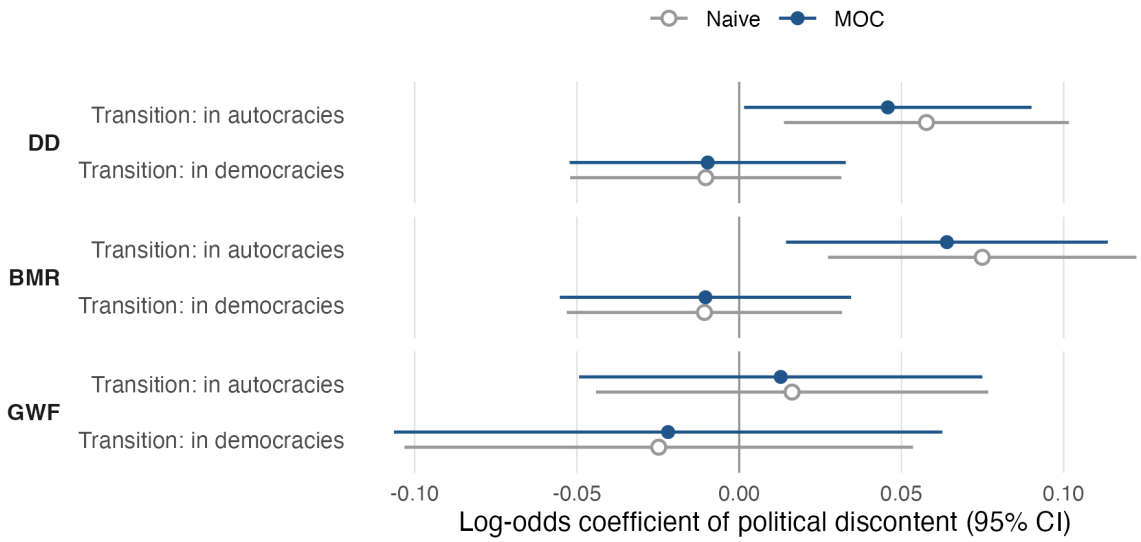


Figure 3: Coefficients from discrete-time hazard models of completed regime transitions under canonical regime codings.

democracies under either coding. The GWF estimates follow a similar directional pattern, with a positive association in autocracies and a negative association in democracies, but neither estimate is statistically distinguishable from zero. We argue that this null effect results from GWF's shorter temporal coverage, which ends in 2010, leaving considerably fewer transition events.

At first glance, the DD and BMR findings appear somewhat inconsistent with the ERT results reported above. Under the ERT framework, political discontent predicts the onset of transformation episodes in autocracies but not whether those episodes ultimately result in a democratic transition. Under DD and BMR, by contrast, political discontent is associated with transitions from autocracy to democracy. An event-level comparison, however, shows that these codings identify substantially different sets of completed regime changes, as shown in Table 1. Among the 46 ERT democratization episodes ending in democratic transition, only 5 (11%) contain a democratization event identified by DD, and the same number contain one identified by BMR. Conversely, only 20% of DD democratizations and 28% of BMR democratizations occur within an ERT episode that ultimately ends in democratic transition. The correspondence is somewhat greater for democratic breakdown: DD and BMR each identify transitions within 35% of ERT breakdown-ending episodes, while approximately one-third of the breakdowns identified by each dichotomous measure occur within the corresponding ERT episodes. Even DD

Table 1: Event Correspondence across Regime-Transition Codings.

Event	Coding	Events	Captured by ERT	Captured by DD	Captured by BMR	Captured by GWF
Democratization	ERT	46	–	5/46 (11%)	5/46 (11%)	3/33 (9%)
Democratization	DD	25	5/25 (20%)	–	6/24 (25%)	6/13 (46%)
Democratization	BMR	18	5/18 (28%)	6/18 (33%)	–	3/12 (25%)
Democratization	GWF	8	3/8 (38%)	6/8 (75%)	3/8 (38%)	–
Breakdown	ERT	17	–	6/17 (35%)	6/17 (35%)	2/9 (22%)
Breakdown	DD	22	7/22 (32%)	–	10/22 (45%)	4/8 (50%)
Breakdown	BMR	18	6/18 (33%)	10/18 (56%)	–	4/9 (44%)
Breakdown	GWF	6	3/6 (50%)	4/6 (67%)	4/6 (67%)	–

and BMR themselves identify substantially different sets of transition events, indicating that disagreement over completed regime transitions is not unique to the ERT framework.

Taken together, these results reinforce our broader conclusion that political discontent is associated with regime instability in autocracies, while providing less consistent evidence about the political destination of that instability. The ERT framework shows most clearly that political discontent increases the likelihood that an autocracy enters a sustained process of regime transformation, without systematically predicting its direction or eventual outcome. The DD and BMR results indicate that some of this instability is classified as completed democratization under alternative regime definitions. However, the limited correspondence between these democratization events and ERT transition episodes, as well as between DD and BMR themselves, suggests that this conclusion is sensitive to how regime change is conceptualized and coded. Thus, we argue that political discontent is more consistently associated with the destabilization of autocratic regimes than with whether that destabilization ultimately culminates in democracy.

Summary and Discussion

This study examines the relationship between political discontent and regime instability. In autocracies, countries with higher political discontent are more likely to enter a sustained episode of regime transformation. Yet discontent does not consistently predict whether that transformation moves toward democracy or autocracy, or how it ultimately ends. In democracies, we do not find evidence of an association between discontent and episode onset. Political discontent therefore appears to be an initiator of instability in autocracies rather than a reliable predictor of its destination.

The autocratic findings suggest a possible division between the roles of masses and elites

in regime transformation. Public discontent may make an authoritarian regime more vulnerable without determining what follows. This perspective may help explain why similar pressures from below can lead to very different outcomes. Recent crises in Belarus (2020) and Kazakhstan (2022) provide illustrative examples. In both cases, widespread public discontent generated serious challenges to authoritarian rule, but the subsequent trajectory depended heavily on elite cohesion, coercive institutions, and external support or intervention. These cases illustrate why the forces that initiate regime instability may differ from those that determine its political destination.

The comparison across regime datasets provides a second implication. ERT, DD, BMR, and GWF are not interchangeable measures of the same regime changes; they identify substantially different sets of events. Accordingly, ERT shows a clear relationship between discontent and the onset of transformation in autocracies without a consistent relationship with eventual democratic transition, whereas under the DD and BMR codings, political discontent in autocracies is positively associated with transitions to democracy. Researchers should therefore choose measures of regime change based on the theoretical construct they seek to explain rather than treat dataset choice as a purely technical decision.

The different findings for democracies and autocracies point to two directions for future research. For autocracies, future work should examine the institutional and elite conditions that connect public discontent to particular regime outcomes. If discontent helps initiate instability but does not determine its destination, the next question is what conditions turn such instability into democratization, further autocratization, or stalled transformation. For democracies, future research should directly test our proposed electoral mechanism by examining whether the relationship between discontent and regime instability varies with electoral competitiveness, executive constraints, or other forms of political accountability. Discontent may also have slower consequences that are not captured by the onset of a regime-transformation episode, including support for populist or personalistic political actors and gradual institutional erosion (Li et al. Working Paper).

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Online Supplementary Materials

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